

TOASTED COCONUT ICE CREAM

Makes about 1 quart (1l)

I'll admit that my favorite selection from the shiny white Good Humor truck that cruised our neighborhood was simply called "coconut": vanilla ice cream on a stick, coated with lots of sweet shredded coconut. Just hearing the bells as the truck rounded the corner to our street sent me racing to my mother, to cajole 35¢ out of her, so I could buy one.

On the last fateful day that I'd ever see the Good Humor man, the bully next door decided to spray him with water from a garden hose as he circled our block. For safety reasons, the trucks were outfitted so they couldn't drive very fast so even though the driver repeatedly floored the gas pedal, he couldn't outrun the bully who followed him with the water-spewing hose.

The driver beat hasty retreat and never came back. Being blackballed by the Good Humor man made that the worst summer of my life. I don't know what happened to the neighborhood bully, but now that I'm an adult I can have coconut-flavored ice cream whenever I want. And I do.

1. Preheat the oven to 350°F (175°C). Spread the coconut on a rimmed baking sheet and bake for 5 to 8 minutes, stirring frequently so it toasts evenly. Remove from the oven when it's nice and fragrant and golden brown.

2. In a medium saucepan, warm the milk, 1 cup (250ml) of the cream, the sugar, and the salt, then add the toasted coconut. Use a paring knife and scrape all the vanilla seeds into the warm milk, then add the pod as well. Cover, remove from the heat, and let steep at room temperature for 1 hour.

3. Rewarm the coconut-infused mixture. Set a mesh strainer over another medium saucepan and strain the coconut-infused liquid through the strainer into the saucepan. Press down on the coconut very firmly with a flexible rubber spatula to extract as much of the flavor from it as possible. Remove the vanilla bean pieces (rinse and reserve them for another use) and discard the coconut.

4. Pour the remaining 1 cup (250ml) heavy cream into a large bowl and set the mesh strainer on top. In a separate medium bowl, whisk together the egg yolks. Slowly pour the warm coconut-infused mixture into the egg yolks, whisking constantly, then scrape the warmed egg yolks into the saucepan. Stir the mixture constantly with a heatproof spatula over medium heat, scraping the bottom as you stir, until the mixture thickens and coats the spatula.

5. Pour the custard through the strainer and stir it into the cream. Mix in the vanilla extract and stir over an ice bath until cool.

6. Chill the mixture thoroughly in the refrigerator, then freeze it in your ice cream maker according to the manufacturer's instructions.

1 cup (70g) dried shredded coconut, preferably unsweetened

1 cup (250ml) whole milk

2 cups (500ml) heavy cream

¾ cup (150g) sugar

Big pinch of kosher or sea salt

1 vanilla bean, split in half lengthwise

5 large egg yolks

½ teaspoon pure vanilla extract or 1 teaspoon rum